

6.3.5 Methods of assessment

It is your responsibility to choose the best method of assessing a student in relation to their individual circumstances. The methods chosen must be:

- valid
- reliable
- safe and manageable
- suitable to the needs of the student.

Valid

Validity can be compromised if a student does not understand what is being asked of them. For example, one valid method of assessing a student's knowledge and understanding is to question them. If the questions posed are difficult for the student to understand (not in terms of the content but the way they are phrased, for example) the validity of the assessment method is questionable.

As well as assessment methods being valid, the evidence presented must also be valid. For example, it would not be appropriate to present an organisation's equal opportunities policy as evidence towards a student's understanding of how the equal opportunities policy operates within the organisation. It would be more appropriate for the student to incorporate the policy within a report describing different approaches to equal opportunities.

Reliable

A reliable method of assessment will produce consistent assessment results for different teachers assessing on each occasion. Internal moderators must make sure that all teachers' assessment decisions are consistent.

Safe and manageable

You must make sure that the assessment methods and approaches taken:

- are safe and manageable
- do not put unnecessary demands on the student
- are appropriate and in line with ethical standards and your centre's safeguarding responsibilities.

Suitable to the needs of the student

We are committed to ensuring that achievement of these qualifications is free from unnecessary barriers. You must follow this commitment through when considering assessment.

Observation and questioning

The primary evidence for assessment is the work submitted by the student, however we consider the following assessment methods suitable for teachers/assessors to use for these qualifications:

- **observation** of a student doing something
- **questioning** of the student or witness.

Observation

You and the student should plan observations together, but it is your responsibility to record the observation properly (for example observing a student undertaking a practical task). Find more information in the Teacher Observation Records section below.

Questioning

Questioning the student is normally an ongoing part of the formative assessment process and may, in some circumstances, provide evidence to support achievement of the criteria.

Questioning is often used to:

- test a student's understanding of work which has been completed outside of the classroom (where this may be permitted)
- check if a student understands the work they have completed
- collect information on the type and purpose of the processes a student has gone through.

If questioning is to be used as evidence towards achievement of specific topic areas, it is important that you record enough information about what you asked and how the student replied, to allow the assessment decision to be moderated.